Remembering Kamaladevi Chattopadhyay



Early Life

Kamaladevi was born on April 3, 1903, in Mangalore, the youngest daughter of Ananthaya Dhareshwar and his wife Girijamma.

She was married at 14 and was widowed only two years later.

Kamala later became friends with Suhasini Chattopadhyay, Sarojini Naidu's younger sister, who introduced Kamala to their older brother Harindranath.

The two bonded over a love for the arts and theatre and got married in the face of much societal opposition.



Education

Her father-in-law was a progressive thinker and encouraged her to continue her education. She studied at Queen Mary's College in Chennai.

Later, Kamala followed Harindranath to the UK to further educate herself and earned a degree in Sociology from London.

Political Life



Upon her return, to India, Kamaladevi joined the Indian National Congress in 1927.

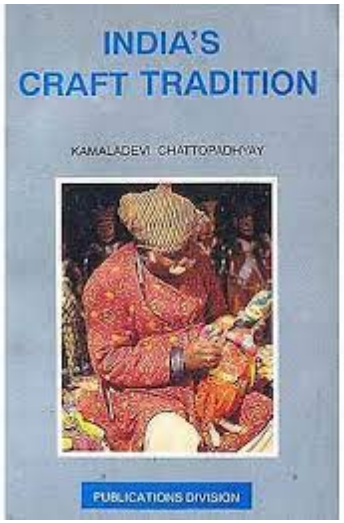
Politics as a career choice for women was rare at the time, and this choice for Chattopadhyay was one of many firsts for the women of the country.

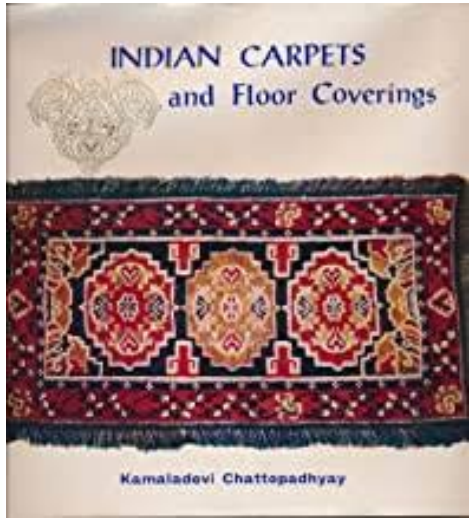
She joined the Seva Dal and became an outspoken supporter of the Salt Satyagraha.

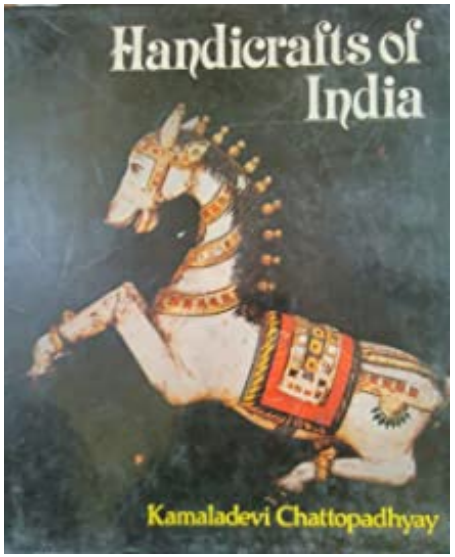
She was one of the few national leaders who signed the new Constitution of India document after Independence.

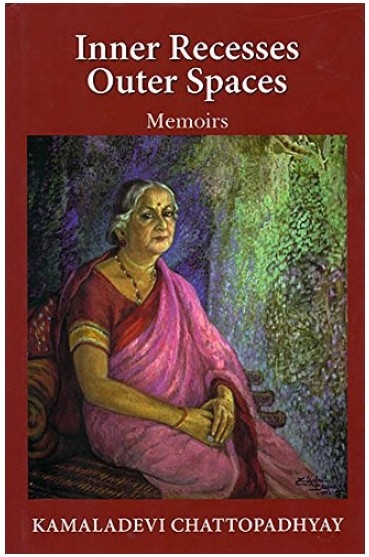
During World War II, she extensively toured the US and other parts of the world, drumming up support for Indian independence.

She propounded that civil rights, environmental justice, religious freedoms and political independence were all inter-related issues.









The Writer

Kamaladevi wrote about 20 books, many of which were inspired by her personal visits to other countries. These are some of her books on craft:

- Handicrafts of India
- Indian Carpets and Floor Coverings
- Indian embroidery
- India's Craft Tradition
- Indian Handicrafts
- The Glory of Indian Handicrafts
- Inner Recesses, Outer Spaces: Memoirs



The Social Reformer

After Partition, Kamaladevi worked tirelessly to set up the city of Faridabad where refugees from the Northwest Frontier province could be resettled.

She worked relentlessly for the upliftment of women and pioneered the cooperative movement which helped raise the socio-economic status of women around the country.

She also contributed immensely to the global discourse on feminism



The Actress

Kamaladevi acted in the following films:

- *Tansen* starring K. L. Saigal and Khursheed
- *Mricchakatika* (Vasantsena) in 1931
- *Shankar Parvati* (1943)
- *Dhanna Bhagat* (1945), first silent movie in the Kannada film industry



Reviving Indian Handicrafts

The Kamaladevi that most Indians are familiar with is a figure who, above all, revived Indian handicrafts, became the country's best-known expert on carpets, puppets, and its thousands of craft traditions, and nurtured a majority of the country's national institutions charged with the promotion of dance, drama, art, theatre, music, and puppetry. To name a few:

- National School of Drama
- Bharatiya Natya Sangha
- Lady Irwin College
- Sangeet Natak Academy
- Central Cottage Industries Emporium
- World Craft Council
- Craft Council of India
- Delhi Craft Council



Awards

The Government of India conferred on her the **Padma Bhushan i**n 1955, and **the Padma Vibhushan** in 1987.

She was awarded the **Ramon Magsaysay Award** in 1966 for Community Leadership.

In 1974, she was awarded the Sangeet Natak Akademi Fellowship**, Ratna Sadasya,** in recognition of her lifetime's work. The Fellowship is the highest award of Sangeet Natak Akademi, India's National Academy of Music, Dance and Drama.

UNESCO honoured her with an award in 1977 for her contribution towards the promotion of handicrafts.

Shantiniketan honoured her with the **Desikottama,** its highest award.

On 3 April 2018, on what would have been her 115th birthday, Google honoured her with a Doodle on their homepage.



References

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